controversially, speculation has long abounded that around the third century Japan suffered an invasion of horse-riding Koreans, who went on to found the first great clans, including perhaps the imperial family itself.

Since Japan's modern period began with the 1868 Meiji Restoration, the country has been inextricably, and at times tragically, linked with the rest of the world. In many ways, Japan remains the test case of non-Western modernization, even one hundred and fifty years after the political event that drove it to radically break with its past. Yet in the century and a half since midlevel samurai overthrew the feudal hierarchy, the country has painstakingly navigated between embracing the outer world and retaining core elements of its culture and society. As much as Japan is celebrated for becoming the first non-Western, non-Christian country to develop a modern political and economic system, it is often criticized for keeping itself closed off from other nations and cultures.

These plaudits and criticisms have taken on particular relevance since current prime minister Shinzo Abe took office in late 2012. A conservative often labeled a nationalist, Abe has moved boldly to increase Japan's role abroad, increase its influence throughout Asia, and loosen restrictions on security cooperation that have been in place for decades. While some see Abe's moves as designed to erase Japan's seventy years of diplomatic and military impotence after 1945, others see him as a danger to continued peace and stability in Asia.

In reality, Abe's attempts to normalize Japan's foreign and security policies are limited by how much internal change he and other Japanese are willing to accept. Attempts by Japan to take a leadership role in Asia, largely in response to the rapid rise of China in the past quarter century, are constrained by an equally powerful desire not to get too involved in the outer world. In other words, Japan's role in the world remains tethered to its conceptions of "Japanese-ness" and a desire to maintain its national identity in a world of flux.

Japan's recent history forces us to consider how open borders need to be and to judge the trade-offs societies are willing to accept between